

0.0.1 The Triple Knowledge (excerpt)

1. Thus was heard by me: At one time the Auspicious One was wandering on tour in Kosala with a large Sangha of bhikkhus, with about five hundred bhikkhus, when they arrived at a brahmin village of the Kosalans named Manasakata. There the Auspicious One dwelled at a mango grove north of Manasakata on the bank of the Aciravati river.

2. At that time many well-known wealthy brahmins were dwelling at Manasakata, such as: the brahmin Canki, the brahmin Tarukkha, the brahmin Pokkharasati, the brahmin Janussoṇi, the brahmin Todeyya, and many other well-known and wealthy brahmins.

3. Now for Vasettha and Bharadvaja, while walking and wandering about, walking along back and forth, this topic of conversation about path and non-path arose. Then the brahmin youth Vasettha said thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this [path] declared by the brahmin Pokkharasati.”

4. The brahmin youth Bharadvaja said thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this [path] declared by the brahmin

Tarukkha.” Neither was the brahmin youth Vasettha able to convince the brahmin youth Bharadvaja, nor was the brahmin youth Bharadvaja able to convince the brahmin youth Vasettha.

5. So then, the brahmin youth Vasettha address the brahmin youth, Bharadvaja. Master Bharadvaja, there is this samana Gotama, son of the Sakyans who has gone forth from the Sakyan clan, dwelling at Manasakata, in a mango grove north of Manasakata on the bank of the Aciravati river. Now a good reputation has been spread about that Auspicious Gotama thus: “Truly is he the Auspicious One, the Arahant, rightly self-awakened, excelling in knowledge and conduct, well-farer, knower of worlds, incomparable charioteer of tamed persons, teacher of devas and humans, awakened, auspicious.” We must visit with the samana Gotama, O Master Bharadvaja. Upon arrival, we must ask the samana Gotama about this matter. In which ever way the samana Gotama will answer, in just that way we must bear it in mind.” “Yes sir.” The brahmin youth Bharadvaja replied to the brahmin youth Vasettha.

6. So then, the brahmin youths Vasettha and Bharadvaja visited with the Auspicious One. Having approached, they exchanged friendly greetings with the Auspicious One. Having exchanged friendly greetings and cordial talk, they sat down to one side. Having sat down to one side, the brahmin youth Vasettha said this to the Auspi-

cious One: “Here Master Gotama, for us while walking and wandering about, walking along back and forth, this topic of conversation about path and non-path arose. I said thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this [path] declared by the brahmin Pokkharasati.” The brahmin youth Bharadvaja said thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this [path] declared by the brahmin Tarukkha.” Here Master Gotama, there is really a dispute, there is a contention, there is a difference of views.”

7. Thus apparently, O Vasettha, you say thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this [path] declared by the brahmin Pokkharasati.” The brahmin youth Bharadvaja say thus: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma, which is this [path] declared by the brahmin Tarukkha.” But what, O Vasettha, is your dispute, what is the contention, what is the difference of views?”

8. “About path and non-path, O Master Gotama. Even though, O Master Gotama, the brahmins declare various paths: that of the Addhariya brahmins, the Tittiriya brah-

mins, the Chandoka brahmins, the Bavhirica brahmins, they all lead to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma. Just as, O Master Gotama, not too far from a village or market town, even if there are various paths, all converge on the village. So too, O Master Gotama, even though the brahmins declare various paths: that of the Addhariya brahmins, the Tittiriya brahmins, the Chandoka brahmins, the Bavhirica brahmins, they all lead to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma.”

9. Do you say, “delivering,” O Vasettha?

10. I say, “delivering,” O Master Gotama.

11. Do you say, “delivering,” O Vasettha?

12. I say, “delivering,” O Master Gotama.

13. Do you say, “delivering,” O Vasettha?

14. I say, “delivering,” O Master Gotama.

15. “But how about this, O Vasettha. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, is there even one brahmin who is able to see Brahma?”

16. Indeed not, O Master Gotama.

17. “But how about this, O Vasettha. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, is there even one teacher who is able to see Brahma?”

18. Indeed not, O Master Gotama.

19. “But how about this, O Vasettha. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, is there even one teacher of teachers who is able to see Brahma?”

20. Indeed not, O Master Gotama.

21. “But how about this, O Vasettha. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, is there even one in the seven generations of teachers who is able to see Brahma?”).

22. Indeed not, O Master Gotama.

23. “But how about this, O Vasettha. Even the ancient triple-knowledge brahmin seers, composers of the mantras, proclaimers of the mantras, this ancient mantra verses proclaimed and composed [by them], of which at present, the triple-knowledge brahmins chant, recite, rehearse, continuously repeating what was said, causing to pass down what has been recited, that is to say: Attaka,

Vamaka, Vamadeva, Vessamitta, Yamataggi, Angirasa, Bharadvaja, Vasettha, Kassapa, Bhagu, do they even speak thus: “We know thus, we see thus, how Brahma or when Brahma or where Brahma [appears].”

24. Indeed not, O Master Gotama.

25. Thus apparently, O Vasettha, among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one brahmin who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one teacher who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one teacher of teachers who is able to see Brahma. Among any of the triple-knowledge brahmins, there is not even one in the seven generations of teachers who is able to see Brahma.

26. Apparently, even the ancient triple-knowledge brahmin seers, composers of the mantras, proclaimers of the mantras, this ancient mantra verses proclaimed and composed [by them], of which at present, the triple-knowledge brahmins chant, recite, rehearse, continuously repeating what was said, causing to pass down what has been recited, that is to say: Attaka, Vamaka, Vamadeva, Vessamitta, Yamataggi, Angirasa, Bharadvaja, Vasettha, Kassapa, Bhagu, even they do not speak thus: “We know thus, we see thus, how Brahma or when Brahma or where Brahma [appears].” Surely those triple-knowledge brahmins who speak thus: “We teach the

path to union with that which we do not know, to that which we do not see, this is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma.”

27. “So what do you think, O Vasettha, that being so, doesn’t the statements of those triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be less than stellar?”

28. “Certainly, O Master Gotama, that being so, the statements of those triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be less than stellar.”

29. Good Vasettha. Indeed O Vasettha, that those triple-knowledge brahmins [could] teach a path to union with that which they do not know, that which they do not see, [claiming]: “This is the only straight path, this is the direct path leading to emancipation, delivering the doer thereof to union with Brahma,” this possibility is not to be found. Just as, O Vasettha, a line of blind men go on in succession holding on to each other, the first one does not see, the middle one too does not see, the last one too does not see. So too, O Vasettha, the statements of the triple-knowledge brahmins seem to me like a line of blind men; the first one does not see, the middle one too does not see, the last one too does not see. These statements of the triple-knowledge brahmins turn out to be mere speech, turn out to be mere words, turn out to be simply empty, turn out to be simply hollow.